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A Tale of Two Nations



Almost three weeks after the River Kosi breached its embankments and swamped a large swathe of Bihar, our response as a nation to such a massive human tragedy has clearly been wanting. Over two million rendered homeless, hundreds dead and vast areas of property damaged—this is India's Katrina. Yet rescue and relief measures remain painfully short, the National Disaster Management Authority is still ill-equipped to make a substantial difference and our national and state leaders continue to play politics over the graves of our citizens. We as a nation, it saddens me to say, still do not seem to learn from our mistakes and therefore, as philosopher George Santayana said, are condemned to repeat them.

Take the way China handled its spate of crises before the Olympics. When the Tibet issue blew up, the Chinese leaders made a hash by using the baton and the gun to brutally quell protests. They hardly seemed to care what the world thought. But soon after when the Sichuan earthquake struck in May 2008, and over 15 million people were badly affected, the entire nation acted as one and won the world's praise. Chinese President Hu Jintao visited the spot and personally supervised relief operations. People from all over China volunteered to help out and donations came pouring in. The tragedy succeeded in uniting a nation. It was a forerunner for the Olympics success to follow.

In contrast, India's political leadership let us down on two of the major crises that could have shown what a great country we really are. The Jammu and Kashmir crisis was allowed to boil for so long that it succeeded in pushing the Valley to the brink and only now has the Government been able to apply some balm. All right, so Jammu and Kashmir was our Tibet. Shouldn't we as a nation have learned from it, so that when the next crisis hit us, we would react as the Chinese nation did? Bihar's sorrow was our chance as a nation to show that our heart beats as one and that we, as a nation, are capable of compassion, generosity and responsibility. Every which way we could have helped Bihar as a nation we should have. Whether expert help to mitigate the flooding waters or relief and healthcare for affected citizens and their rehabilitation. We had shown we could do that in the past—when the Tsunami struck India in 2004. We can still do it as a nation—Bihar needs all our help. If you care for India, prepare to show it now.



SAURABH SINGH

ADVENTURE ISLAND:
The amusement park



CPI(M) Pvt Ltd

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM It owns a television channel, a multi-edition newspaper, several hospitals and enterprises that manufacture everything from bidis to bedsheets. And last week, it opened a multi-crore amusement park in Kerala's northern Kannur district. A big corporate house? Far from it. Among the biggest entrepreneurs in the industrially backward state is the ruling CPI(M), which entered a new field of business by gifting the people of Kerala a Rs 30-crore amusement park with everything from water rides to gut-wrenching roller coasters. Vismaya, as it is called, is run by the Malabar Pleasures (India) Pvt Ltd which is an offshoot of a CPI(M)-run cooperative. But make no mistake, the prices are hardly proletarian. Tickets are priced at Rs 300 on weekdays and Rs 375 on weekends and its owners said they expect at least a thousand visitors every day and gate collections to touch Rs 4 lakh daily.

Predictably, contro-

versy surrounded the park's inauguration. Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan who firmly believes that the Marxist party has no business running such Mickey Mouse ventures, stayed away leaving his bete noire Pinarayi Vijayan to cut the ribbon. There were also charges that the setting up of a park with several water rides would lead to depletion of groundwater resources in the area. But Vijayan allayed such fears saying that all "water requirements for the park were being met by rain water harvesting. The park has the largest such facility in the country".

The Opposition Congress said the CPI(M) was acting more like a multinational company. "In the very week that they raised water charges for ordinary consumers in the state, they opened up a theme park that uses 25,000 litres of water," said KPCC president Ramesh Chennithala. Commies' own waters?

by M.G. Radhakrishnan